and phases of the battle. This rigmarole continued for almost a year, preoccupied as we were with the happenings in Eastern Ladakh. Ultimately, I had to put my foot down and give out the bottom line, up to and around which the proposal had to be finalized. This was probably the only time I raised my voice in the face of such obduracy. Fortunately for me, I had an ally in Lt Gen Mohanty, who had taken over as the VCOAS in January 2021 and was totally on board. He could then push through the changes and vet them before it was presented to me, thus saving me time.

There remained the question of obtaining Ministry approval as it constituted a policy change, including few accretions in higher ranks, since each IBG would now be commanded by a Maj Gen. Overall though, the proposal was financially beneficial, as it would result in a substantial reduction in manpower to the tune of 1500 to 2000 personnel per Corps. The proposal was forwarded to the DMA with a request to schedule a presentation for the RM in the presence of other stakeholders, especially Defence Finance, who would have to obtain the sanction of the Secretary, Finance of the Finance Ministry as per the policy in vogue.[3] Although I had briefed the RM a number of times on these ongoing efforts, a conference requiring the attendance of other Secretaries could only be convened on behalf of the RM, by the DMA. After a couple of months, we received a communication from the DMA that approval of the RM already existed for such a restructuring, even quoting the authority. This was news to me but ought to have been known to the CDS since he was the former COAS.

Explaining this concept to the environment was a Herculean effort, as everyone was seeing it as a cost-cutting exercise. I had to emphasize time and again that whatever

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